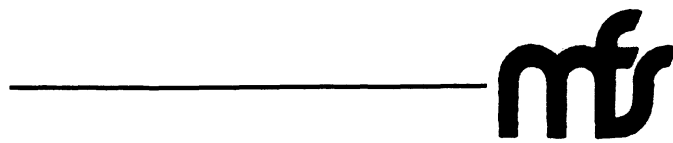


ON THE WRITING OF FUTURE-HISTORY:
BEGINNING THE ENDING IN DORIS LESSING'S
THE MEMOIRS OF A SURVIVOR



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I

DORIS LESSING'S MANIFESTO on the novelist's "commitment," "The Small Personal Voice," has understandably trained the reader's eye to recognize the social themes present in her fiction. But Lessing has been disturbed by the limited readings of feminist and socialist critics who artificially separate the content of her novels from their form. In her important "Preface" to *The Golden Notebook*, Lessing writes "that if [*The Golden Notebook*] were shaped in the right way it would make its own comment about the conventional novel. . . . My major aim was to shape a book which would make its own comment, a wordless statement: to talk through the way it was shaped."¹ The structuring of the text, therefore, is a statement of how the novel is to be read. One can, in formulating a method for reading the Lessing text, apply Lessing's statement to both the intricate construction of *The Golden Notebook* and to *The Memoirs of a Survivor*. Published thirteen years after *The*

¹Doris Lessing, "Preface," *The Golden Notebook* (New York: Bantam Books, 1973), pp. xiii-iv.

Golden Notebook, the *Memoirs* is another novel in which Lessing exhibits her fascination with complex narrative forms, and in reading the *Memoirs*, "one realizes," to borrow a phrase from Jean Ricardou, "how the novel ceases to be the writing of a story to become the story of a writing."²

Ricardou's idea of the reader's realization of the act of writing suggests a method for the act of reading Lessing's intricate narrative structures. In his essay "Les catégories du récit littéraire," Tzvetan Todorov postulates a science of reading which is the study of "'literariness'" rather than the study of literature; in Lessing's terms, the study of a narrative's "shape," its "wordless statement." In the act of reading, according to Todorov, "'literariness'" is perceived by the reader's separation of the novel's *histoire*, its story, from its *discours*, the story's shaping by a narrator, the story of the writing.³ The *Memoirs'* *discours* is the "memoirs" of the unnamed narrator and to ignore the act of writing by the narrator is to misread the text. The act of writing in a Lessing text constructs what Roland Barthes calls "enigmas," narrative statements that are incomplete, questions for which the narrator and the reader are compelled to provide answers.⁴ These enigmas are structural elements in the *discours* rather than in the *histoire*, and they cause in the act of reading a multiplicity of possible interpretation, a level of difficulty—essential to the literary text—in the transference of the message from the sender to the receiver. One particular enigma in the *Memoirs* (discussed later in this essay) centers around the narrator's concern with the meaning of "it." Moreover, Lessing increases this level of difficulty in the *Memoirs* by creating as the sender of the text a first person narrator who is anonymous and known to the reader only through her narration, who is writing a memoir which is the record of two planes of consciousness, and who claims to be writing a "history." But how can this be a "history" if the time of the fiction is the future, a time prior to the time of the reading?

At the end of the seventh section of the novel, at the precise center point of both the narrative and the physical book, the narrator writes:

²Jean Ricardou, "Temps de la narration, temps de la fiction," *Problèmes du nouveau roman* (Paris: Seuil, 1967); trans. Joseph Kestner, in *James Joyce Quarterly*, 16, No. 1-2 (Fall 1978/Winter 1979), 11.

³Todorov formulates his ideas of *histoire* and *discours* in his seminal essay "Les catégories du récit littéraire," *Communications*, 8 (1966), 125-151 [a translation by Joseph Kestner of this essay will appear in *Papers on Language and Literature*]; moreover, Lessing's attitudes toward narrative shaping and the inadequacies of the "conventional novel" bear some affinities to Todorov's statement in "The Origin of Genres" (trans. Richard M. Berrong, in *New Literary History*, 8, No. 1 [Autumn 1976], 159): "the evolution of modern literature consists precisely in making each work a questioning of the very being of literature."

⁴Roland Barthes, *S/Z*, trans. Richard Miller (New York: Hill & Wang, 1974), p. 19 and *passim*; for Barthes, enigmas form an integral part of the hermeneutic code in a piece of writing and are essential to the transfer of meaning from the sender to the receiver.

"This is a history, after all, and I hope a truthful one."⁵ This overt labeling of the narrative as "history" raises questions of genre which seriously affect the reading of the *Memoirs*. Instead of "Memoirs," Lessing had first titled the novel a "Journal."⁶ Both possibilities focus attention on the text as document, the consciously written object, but a journal signifies a degree of simultaneity between the time of the fiction and the time of the narration,⁷ while the *Memoirs* is written from a retrospective point of view; it is the "survivor's" account. But what has the narrator survived? "History" connotes in the *Memoirs* not a sense of something past, but a way of reading in which actions or events have, to quote Tolstoy (one of Lessing's favorite writers), "not a free but a predestined significance."⁸ This sense of historical inevitability, fused with the future world of the *Memoirs*, must undergird any reading of the *Memoirs* if Lessing's vision of future-history is to be perceived. In order to read this message, however, the reader must grasp the narrative's "shape" and understand how Lessing constructs her "wordless statement."

II

We all remember that time. It was no different for me than for others. Yet we do tell each other over and over again the particularities of the events we shared, and the repetition, the listening, is as if we are saying, "It was like that for you, too? Then that confirms it, yes it was so, it must have been, I wasn't imagining things." We match or dispute like people who have seen remarkable creatures on a journey: "Did you see that big blue fish? Oh, the one you saw was yellow!" But the sea we travelled over was the same, the protracted period of unease and tension before the end was the same for everybody, everywhere; in the smaller units of our cities—streets, a cluster of tall flats, a hotel—as in cities, nations, a continent. . . . Yes, I agree that this is pretty highflown imagery considering the nature of the events in question: bizarre fish, oceans, and so forth. But perhaps it wouldn't be out of place here to comment on the way we—everyone—will look over a period in life, over a sequence of events, and find much more there than they did

⁵Doris Lessing, *The Memoirs of a Survivor* (New York: Bantam Books, 1976), p. 110; all subsequent references are cited parenthetically within the text.

⁶Doris Lessing's typescripts for the *Memoirs* are unpublished at the present time; however, the typescripts (three heavily worked complete drafts and one final copy) held at the University of Tulsa contain fifteen alternative titles prior to the final title. All of the alternative titles, with the exception of the final two, are concerned with either Emily, the narrator's foster-child, or the narrator's "'personal'" world behind one of her living-room walls. The final title decision appears to have been made during the composition of the second complete draft, since the final choice is written for the first time on the folder cover for the second draft, among other titles.

⁷See Ricardou; briefly, Ricardou's point is that the novelist achieves various effects (i.e., retarding or accelerating the narrative) by constructing a temporal tension between the narrator's point of view and the action he is describing. Therefore, the degree of detachment between the narrator and the story (the *discours* and the *histoire*) reflects the reliability of the narrator. As the narrator states in the *Memoirs*: "perhaps it wouldn't be out of place here to comment on the way we—everyone—will look over a period in life, over a sequence of events, and find much more than they did at the time" (p. 3).

⁸Leo Tolstoy, *War and Peace*, trans. Louise and Aylmer Maude and ed. George Gibian (New York: A Norton Critical Edition, 1966), p. 670; Lessing has often remarked her regard for Tolstoy among other nineteenth-century authors; see, *A Small Personal Voice* (New York: Vintage Books, 1975), pp. 4-5.

at the time. This is true even of events as dispiriting as the litter left on a common after a public holiday. People will compare notes, as if wishing or hoping for confirmation of something they had seemed to exclude altogether. Happiness? That's a word I have taken up from time to time in my life, looked at—but never did I find it held its shape. A meaning, then; a purpose? Nostalgia—no, I'm not talking of that, the craving, the regret—not that poisoned itch. Nor is it a question of the importance each one of us tries to add to our not very significant pasts: "*I was there, you know. I saw that.*"

But it is because of this propensity of ours that perhaps I may be permitted the fancy metaphors. I *did* see a fish in that sea, as if whales and dolphins had chosen to show themselves coloured scarlet and green, but they did not understand at the time what it was I was seeing, and certainly did not know how much of my own personal experience was common, was shared: this is what, looking back, we acknowledge first—our similarities, not our differences. (pp. 3-4)

Thus the novel, the time of the narration, begins, but with the first sentence, "We all remember that time," the reader is immediately aware of the narrative's *proleptic* and *analeptic* shaping.⁹ The narrator, from her *analeptic* (retrospective) point of view, constructs a *proleptic* (anticipatory) beginning by speaking about the "end." Roland Barthes, in *S/Z*, writes: "By participating in the need to set forth the *end* of every action (conclusion, interruption, closure, denouement) the readerly [text] declares itself to be historical."¹⁰ However, the narrative dislocation caused by the paradoxical temporal structure disrupts the reading process. Moreover, the narrator's regular usage of the first-person plural "we" makes the reader a collaborator with the narrator, and, though the reader is warned against "nostalgia," the narrator constructs a pervasive sense of a common past, a Jungian collective consciousness¹¹ of social movement and change.

As stated earlier, the reader is also increasingly aware of the *Memoirs* as "memoirs" of a future time, the chronicle of a future-history. The unnamed city depicted by the narrator is suffering from an entropic decay which has been progressively breaking down the societal order over a period of time. The breakdown of order, a theme Lessing has used often in her fiction, is nearly total: communication systems do not work, the utilities are shut off, citizen's willfully break the law, and young children roam the streets in wild gangs, violently destroying whatever threatens their instinctive urge to survive. The temporal disruption in the *Memoirs* of the conventional retrospective method of story-telling is mirrored by the breakdown of the communication systems in the story. The narrator, like the citizens she describes, willfully breaks the laws of narrative form, the telling of something past, to circumvent the

⁹See Gérard Genette, *Figures III* (Paris: Seuil, 1972), pp. 82-121; *Narrative Discourse: An Essay in Method*, trans. Jane E. Lewin (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1980), pp. 40-85.

¹⁰Barthes, p. 52.

¹¹For discussions of Lessing's Jungian influences see Mary Ann Singleton, *The City and the Veld: The Fiction of Doris Lessing* (Lewisburg, PA: Bucknell University Press, 1977); and Ellen Cronan Rose, "The End of the Game: New Directions in Doris Lessing's Fiction," *The Journal of Narrative Technique*, 6, No. 1 (Winter 1976), 66-75.

broken, or meaningless, or controlled systems of communication. For her message to be received fully, the narrator must write her memoirs employing a new transmission frequency: the *proleptic analepse* of future-history.

But a second narrative disruption arises in the narrator's choice of her standing place within the time of the fiction. The distinction between the hermetic world of the observer and the chaos of the "street" is a common metaphor in Lessing's writing, but in the *Memoirs*, the observation point of the narrator's ground-floor flat is an interface between the happenings on the "street" and the "'personal'" interior world of the narrator's consciousness, depicted by the world behind the wall. The first narrative disruption is the *proleptic analepse* of future-history, and the second is the interpenetration in the *Memoirs* of the narrator's two worlds.¹² Early in her account, the narrator writes of the relationship between the two worlds:

Yes, it was extraordinary. Yes, it was impossible. But after all, I had accepted the "impossible." I lived with it. I had abandoned all expectations of the ordinary for my inner world, my real life in that place. And as for the public, the outer world, it had been a long time since that offered the normal. Could one perhaps describe that period as "the ordinariness of the extraordinary"? Well, the reader should have no difficulty here: these words are a description of the times we have lived through. (A description of all life?—probably, but it is not much help to think so.) (p. 18)

What is interesting in this passage is not the attempt to fix the "'ordinariness of the extraordinary,'" but rather the challenge offered to the reader regarding how to read the text. Once again, the reader is made a collaborator through the use of the narrative "we," and yet the parenthetical statement at the end of the passage seems interjected as a narrative flag, signaling that the reader will not find broad generalizations easily; as the narrator states: "There is nothing that people won't try to accommodate into 'ordinary life'" (p. 19).

A third, and possibly the most crucial, disruption in the text is the problem of text transmission. Obviously, the narrator/reader contact, the *text* of the *Memoirs*, must have a generating point in time, a time of the writing, which must be accomplished prior to the time of the reading so that the narrator and the reader can collaborate. The question raised by a narrative of future-history is whether or not the implied reader, one half of the narrative "we," is the actual reader. The temporal dislocation of future-history hints at a distinction between the implied reader within the text and the actual reader of the document. This distinction is further complicated, however, by the final scene in the *Memoirs*, when the narrator, Emily, Gerald, and the "children" step

¹²Ellen Cronan Rose sees these two worlds as a "Jungian model of the psyche, which comprehends both the personal and the collective unconscious" (p. 72).

into the world behind the wall, entering what previously has been a “‘personal’” world open only to the narrator (though other characters, particularly Emily in various childhood stages, inhabit this “‘personal’” world). If this world behind the wall, this seeming construct of the narrator’s consciousness, is the place where the *Memoirs* is written, as the narrative’s *analeptic* structure would imply, then how is the text transmitted back to the actual reader?

III

Doris Lessing’s firm “commitment” to the novel as a document of social awareness and a possible agent of change does not permit the reader to suspend disbelief and retreat into a passive perception of a fantasy world. The problems and questions raised by the *Memoirs* are intricately part of the shaping of the narrative, the *Memoirs’ discours*, the “statement” made by that “shape.” One can begin to unravel the web of narrative structure in the *Memoirs* by examining the significance the narrator places on the question of beginning and ending. Indeed, the conception of the “survivor” is inherently connected with the sense of something having ended, just as the reader’s sense of the text as “history” depends on a completion of a temporal cycle. Moreover, one of the narrator’s primary tasks is to discover the historical moment when the inevitable spiral toward the end is said to have begun.

On the first page of the *Memoirs*, the narrator raises the question of the “end”: “the protracted period of unease and tension before the end was the same for everybody, everywhere” (p. 3). The definiteness of this statement illuminates the apocalyptic feeling prevalent in the narrative, but this statement also can be read as a paradigm for the reader’s process of reading future-history. The actual “end,” therefore, becomes the temporal point in the narrative when the time of the fiction and the time of the narration are in their closest proximity, the moment when the paradox of future-history is resolved. The “protracted period of unease and tension” reflects the reader’s task of constructing a perception of the text.¹³

¹³According to Victor Shklovsky (“Art as Technique,” in *Russian Formalist Criticism: Four Essays*, ed. and trans. Lee T. Lemon and Marion J. Reis [Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1965], p. 12): “The purpose of art is to impart the sensation of things as they are perceived and not as they are known. The technique of art is to make objects ‘unfamiliar,’ to make forms difficult, to increase the difficulty and length of perception because the process of perception is an aesthetic end in itself and must be prolonged. *In art, it is our experience of the process of construction that counts, not the finished product*” [the italicized passage in Shklovsky’s statement is translated by Robert Scholes and Thomas Winner in Scholes’ essay “The Contributions of Formalism and Structuralism to the Theory of Fiction,” in *Towards a Poetics of Fiction*, ed. Mark Spilka (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1977), p.

Part of this perception, this "unease," centers around "it":

I shall begin this account at a time before we were talking about "it." We were still in the stage of generalised unease. Things weren't too good, they were even pretty bad. A great many things were bad, breaking down, giving up, or "giving cause for alarm," as the newscasts might put it. But "it," in the sense of something felt as an immediate threat which could not be averted, no. (p. 5)

The self-consciousness of the narrator as narrator is clear in this attempt to "begin" the account, but to place this beginning enigmatically "at a time before we were talking about 'it'" forces the reader to become self-conscious of his role as collaborator. In an attempt to define the *signifié*¹⁴ of "it," the narrator remarks "that the use of the word 'it' is always a sign of crisis, of public anxiety" (p. 5). This "anxiety" is reflected in the disruptive elements of the novel's *discours*. The textual difficulty caused by these disruptions demands that the reader actively institute an individualized second system of order to the one on the pages of the *Memoirs*. An important formulation of this process is Jurij Lotman's, in his essay "Primary and Secondary Communication-Modeling Systems":

Specialization in the structure of individual codes—the possibility of a purely personal representation in texts of extralinguistic reality—meets deep needs of the collective as a whole, since a shortage of information typical of any human collective can most effectively be compensated for by the stereoscopic quality, polyglottism, and multi-level character of specialization. Under these circumstances, the difficulty of a synonymous interpretation of the text no longer seems to be a structural defect. It would be possible to show convincingly that certain cultural mechanisms work in the direction of making it difficult to decipher a text adequately; the more complex the structure of a message, the more individual is its interpretation by each recipient of the information. The act of exchanging information ceases to be a passive transfer of a message that is adequate unto itself from one bloc of memory to another and becomes a translation, in the course of which the message is transformed and the striving for adequacy enters into dramatic conflict with the impossibility of its complete realization. The act of communication begins to include the aspect of tension within itself.¹⁵

The anxiety created by what Lotman calls a "dramatic conflict" in the communication act is felt by the reader of the *Memoirs*. The narrator's

113]. Lessing's ideas concerning the message transmitted by the novel's "shape" hints at the reader's need to utilize a process of aesthetic perception similar to the one devised by Shklovsky. For both Lessing and Shklovsky the text must be made difficult so that the reader will abandon his habitual perception of the text, his usual patterns of reading and expectations, and then proceed to re-see the text, to apprehend the "wordless statement" in the narrative "shape."

¹⁴Ferdinand de Saussure's distinction between the *signifiant* (the linguistic unit, or word sign) and its possible *signifiés* (all the possible referents for the *signifiant*) is important in relation to how the reader is intended to perceive the narrator's discussion of "it." The combination of the *signifiant* with its *signifiés* forms the entire semiotic sign. This semiotic sign, particularly in the case of "it," attains a high level of multi-valency when it is used in a poetic text. In her discussion of "it," the narrator lays bare this aspect of language, thereby calling into question the perception of language, the process of reading.

¹⁵Jurij M. Lotman, "Primary and Secondary Communication-Modeling Systems," in *Soviet Semiotics: An Anthology*, ed. and trans. Daniel P. Lucid (Baltimore, MD: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1977), pp. 97-98.

discussion of "'it'" presents the reader with an enigma, which must be resolved if a complete transmission of information is to occur. Moreover, the enigma is semiotic in nature, "the word 'it' is always a sign," calling for a "decipherment" of its place in the narrative coding, the story of the writing.

The narrator opens the tenth section of the *Memoirs* by returning to the enigma, the semiotic sign, "'it'":

I think this is the right place to say something more about "it." Though of course there is no "right" place or time, since there was no particular moment that marked "its" beginning. And yet there did come a period when everyone was talking about "it"; and we knew we had not been doing this until recently: there was a different ingredient in our lives.

Perhaps it might even have been more correct to have begun this chronicle with an attempt at a full description of "it." But is it possible to write an account of anything at all without "it"—in some shape or another—being the main theme? Perhaps, indeed, "it" is the secret theme of all literature and history, like writing between the lines in invisible ink, which springs up, sharply black, dimming the old print we knew so well, as life personal or public, unfolds unexpectedly and we see something where we never thought we could—we see "it" as the ground-swell of events, experience. . . . Very well, then, but what *was* "it"? . . . I am sure that ever since there were men on earth, "it" has been talked of precisely in this way in times of crisis, since it is in crisis "it" becomes visible and our conceit sinks before its force. For "it" is a force, a power, taking the form of earthquake, a visiting comet whose balefulness hangs closer night by night, distorting all thought by fear—"it" can be, has been, pestilence, a war, the alteration of climate, a tyranny that twists men's minds, the savagery of a religion.

"It," in short, is the word for helpless ignorance, or of helpless awareness. (pp. 153-154)

This crucial statement about the acts of writing and reading the *Memoirs* warrants a close textual reading. The narrator's digression to the first chapter, the beginning, severely disrupts the linear narrative as it has progressed from those early pages. Importantly, this digression focuses on an aspect of the *Memoirs'* *discours*: Where should the narrator have discussed "'it'"? Moreover, the narrator calls into question the entire beginning of her "chronicle."

However, prior to directly asking this question about the textual beginning, the narrator re-introduces the narrative "we" by which the textual contact with the reader as collaborator was established. This contact must be re-established in order to make the reader, once again, fully conscious of the narrative's "shape": "But is it possible to write an account of anything at all without 'it'—in some shape or another—being the main theme?" The necessity for this form-consciousness is evident as the narrator fuses the thematic undergirding of the enigma "'it,'" with the *Memoirs* as book. "'It'" becomes the "writing between the lines in invisible ink, which springs up, sharply black, dimming the old print we knew so well." By fusing content with form, the "wordless statement" Lessing demands the reader to perceive is signified: "since it

is in crisis 'it' becomes visible." What becomes "visible" is Lessing's vision of future decay, and the writing between the lines is the palimpsestic rewriting of "history," the original text being future-history.

The narrator's prolonging of the discussion on "'it'" moves the passage closer and closer to a point of closure; the narrator must resolve the enigma. "'It,' in short, is the word for helpless ignorance, or of helpless awareness." The dualism stylistically radiates the narrator's *alternation* in the *discours* between her two worlds,¹⁶ but the delimitation of those worlds is becoming increasingly difficult for the narrator to maintain. The reader shares this experience of "difficulty," in Lotman's sense of the word, and ultimately, the narrator must make a statement concerning "'it,'" and in doing so, she reveals a pattern of the text, a method of reading: "'It,' perhaps—on this occasion in history—was above all, a consciousness of something ending" (p. 154).

Again, the reader is faced with the narrator's "consciousness of something ending" and with the knowledge that the narrative "shape," once it is complete, like the "patterned carpet" which the narrator observes being constructed piece by piece in a room behind the wall, still has something to reveal. Frank Kermode's influential study *The Sense of an Ending* discusses the sense of apocalypse in the literature, particularly the fiction, of Western culture. Kermode is especially interested in how this sense of an ending is reflected in the strategies of closure used in constructing the fictional text; in other words, how the writer conceived of a textual end and then wrote towards that end.¹⁷ Applying this idea to the *Memoirs* reveals the narrator's dual attention to the "end" of her external, "public" world and to the "end" of her text. The problematic nature of the novel's final scene, the walking into the world behind the wall, forces the reader to re-evaluate drastically his act of reading. The narrative "shape," once revealed, re-orders the message's temporal structure as a future-history.

In his essay "The Crisis in the Growth of Science Fiction," Michel Butor writes of the novelist's depiction of life in the future: "We start from the world as we know it, from the society which surrounds us. We introduce a certain number of changes whose consequences we attempt to foresee. By a projection into the future, we open up the complexity of the present."¹⁸ Butor's assertion should be read in relation to Lessing's comment on the *Memoirs* being "an attempt at autobiography" and Victoria Glendinning's response: "If this is autobiography, it is an

¹⁶See Todorov, "Les catégories du récit littéraire," p. 140.

¹⁷Frank Kermode, *The Sense of an Ending* (London: Oxford University Press, 1966).

¹⁸Michel Butor, "The Crisis in the Growth of Science Fiction," in *Inventory*, trans. Richard Howard (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1968), p. 225; Butor's essay is particularly pertinent in light of Lessing's latest novel, *Shikasta* (the first volume of a proposed science fiction tetralogy), which again exhibits Lessing's construction of a novel through the use of documents.

exercise in projection.”¹⁹ These statements lead the reader toward an awareness that the *Memoirs* is the chronicle of a vision, a recounting of a dream of future decay. Lessing does not opt for the tired conventions of realism by having the vision re-dreamed; instead, she creates a narrator who constructs a text. This narrative persona allows for the inversion created by future-history. The world behind the wall is simultaneously another plane of consciousness and a way back to the present. This “‘personal’” world is atemporal, a spatial plane shifting in time, responding to the narrator’s need to construct a counter-reality into which she and the other characters can eventually escape.

To bring this prophetic vision of an entropic world collapse back to the present, the narrator must step through the wall, committing herself to the “‘personal’” world. With the final words of the novel, “the last walls dissolved” (p. 217), the narrator’s observation point on the interface of consciousness disappears. Now the message can be transmitted to the actual reader, who, in turn, becomes one with the implied reader, the collaborator in the vision. The narrator’s regard for the narrative “shape,” the story of the writing, reflects Lessing’s deep concern with the seeming inevitability of society’s decline toward a realization of the vision depicted in the *Memoirs*. The narrative is meant to be *proleptic* in structure; the temporal *analepse* of the telling is a device intended to lay bare the “dramatic conflict” inherent in the transmission of a future-history which signifies more than surreal fantasy. *The Memoirs of a Survivor* is a prophecy, a warning, but its full prophetic message can only be perceived if the “shape” of the narrative and its “wordless statement” are understood.

¹⁹Victoria Glendinning, “The Return of She,” *Times Literary Supplement*, 13 December 1974, p. 1405; Lessing’s comment about the *Memoirs* is quoted in this review of the novel.